Reading is a quiet kind of travel. A person may sit beside a window on a grey afternoon and, with nothing more than a few pages, walk through distant cities, cross wide rivers, and listen to voices that fell silent long ago. The book asks only for attention, and in return it offers a room in which the mind may wander freely.

In the old village by the river there lived a miller who kept a small shelf of books above his table. Each evening, when the wheel had stopped turning and the flour had settled on the floor like early snow, he would take down one volume and read aloud to his children. They did not always understand the words, but they loved the sound of them, and they loved the warm light of the lamp.

The eldest daughter remembered those evenings for the rest of her life. Years later, when she had a house of her own, she placed a shelf above her table in the same way. She found that a story read slowly, one sentence after another, could calm a restless child better than any song.

Spring came early that year. The fields turned green before the last frost had left the hills, and the swallows returned to the eaves of the mill. The miller walked along the bank each morning to look at the water, which ran high and brown with melted snow from the mountains.

There is an art to reading well, and it is not the art of reading quickly. A careful reader pauses at a difficult word, turns it over, and asks what it might mean. A careful reader returns to a passage that moved them and reads it again, finding something new in the second visit that was hidden in the first.

The village school had only one room and one teacher, a patient woman who had come from the city many years before. She taught the children their letters with chalk on a slate, and when they could read a whole sentence without help, she gave each of them a small book to take home and keep.

Some of those books were read so often that their covers fell away and their pages grew soft as cloth. Others were lost in the river, or left in the rain, or given away to a cousin in another town. But the words in them stayed with the children long after the paper was gone.

Autumn brought the harvest and the long evenings. The miller worked late into the night, and the sound of the wheel could be heard across the fields. When at last he came home, his children were often asleep, a book still open on the blanket beside them.

So the years passed in the village by the river. The mill grew old, and the miller grew old with it, but the shelf above the table was never empty. There was always another story waiting, another page to turn, another quiet journey to begin.